

Brazil



South America's only Portuguese-speaking nation was a 19th-century empire in its own right.

1494 The Treaty of Tordesillas sets a boundary between Portuguese and Spanish possessions, which awards Portugal roughly the eastern half of South America.

1500 Pedro Álvares Cabral reaches the Brazilian coast.

1532 First permanent Portuguese settlement at São Vicente in São Paulo; settlement also begins in the northeast.

1549 Salvador is founded as the country's first capital and 12 captaincies are established to govern the country, stretching inland from the coast.

1549 A Captain-General is sent out to establish a centralized government at Bahia. He is accompanied by Jesuits who play a key role in the unification of the colony and the exploration of the interior.

1555 French Protestant Huguenots establish themselves on an island in Rio de Janeiro harbor. They are expelled in 1567 by Mem de Sá, who founds the city of Rio de Janeiro.

1580–1640 Brazil becomes part of the Spanish empire when Spain takes over Portugal.

1630–54 The Dutch control a large sugar-growing region in the northeast. The Portuguese cannot expel them as their country is now part of Spain; in the end, the Dutch are expelled by a naval force sent from Rio de Janeiro.

1630–95 Freed slave settlements oppose the colonialists, particularly at Palmares in the north, under African leader Zumbi.

1763 Rio de Janeiro becomes the national capital.

1789 Inconfidência rebellion, led by Tiradentes, fails to establish Brazilian independence.

1807 The French under Napoleon invade Portugal. King João VI flees to Brazil with a British naval escort. In return, Brazil's ports are opened up to foreign trade.

1821 King João returns to Portugal; his son Pedro is made regent of Brazil.

1822 Pedro declares his independence from Portugal and is made Emperor Pedro I of Brazil. Pedro uses a former British admiral and a former French general to help him drive the Portuguese out of the country. Although no set battles are fought, both sides use guerrilla tactics in the war before the Portuguese eventually withdraw. Portugal recognizes the new country's independence in 1825.

1828 Brazil loses Spanish-speaking Uruguay after a three-year war with Argentina.

1831 Military revolt after war with Argentina. Emperor Pedro I abdicates and is succeeded by his five-year-old son, Pedro II.

1835–45 Rio Grande province in the south of the country secedes.

1850 Brazil abolishes the transatlantic slave trade.

1865–70 Brazil wins the war of the Triple Alliance with Argentina and Uruguay against Paraguay, gaining some territory from Paraguay in the south.

1871 A law for the gradual emancipation of slaves is passed.

1888 While Pedro II is away in Europe, his daughter Isabella governs the country and slavery is completely abolished. The landowners and military turn against the emperor.

1889 The first republic is established, seen as a necessary step by modernizers. Pedro II goes into exile in Paris. Prosperity increases as a result of international demand for coffee.

1891 Federal constitution established. Rivalry between the states and the influence of the army in government cause political tensions.

1903–05 Gains land from Venezuela and Colombia in the northwest, and from Bolivia in the west.

1914–18 World War I in Europe causes coffee exports to slump, but stimulates other sectors and brings an economic boom.

1920s Working-class and intellectual movements call for an end to oligarchic rule.

1929 After the Wall Street Crash, 29 million bags of coffee go unsold.

“By my blood, by my honor, and by God, I will make Brazil free. It is time! **Independence or death.** We are separated from Portugal.”

PEDRO I OF BRAZIL, SPEAKING AT THE IPIRANGA RIVER, SEPTEMBER 7, 1822

1930 Coffee prices collapse. Revolt led by Dr. Getúlio Vargas, the “Father of the Poor,” who becomes president. There is rapid industrial growth as measures are taken to reverse the country's growing economic dependence on coffee through import substitution industrialization.

1937 Vargas's position as benevolent dictator is formalized in the *Estado Novo*, the “New State,” a centralized and corporatist state based on the fascist model. Vargas, although a dictator, wins applause for his nationalist policies and economic success.

1942 Brazil declares war on Germany. The economy booms as raw materials such as rubber are in great demand.

1945 Vargas is forced out by the military. General Eurico Gaspar Dutra is elected president, but the economy falters as inflation soars.

1951 Vargas is reelected president.

1954 State oil monopoly is created. Social security laws are passed.

1954 The US opposes Vargas's socialist policies. The right, backed by the military, demands his resignation. Faced with economic problems and political infighting, he commits suicide. He leaves behind a letter blaming “dark forces” (meaning the US and its local supporters) for blocking his efforts to make reforms.

1956–60 President Juscelino Kubitschek, backed by the Brazilian Labor Party (PTB), attracts foreign investment for new industries, especially from the US.

1960–61 Conservative Jânio da Silva Quadros is elected president with the greatest popular margin in Brazil's history. He tries to break dependence on US trade, but his autocratic and unpredictable manner arouses opposition and undermines his reforms, and he is forced to resign after only seven months in office.

1960 Brasília, built in three years, becomes new capital. PTB leader João Goulart is elected president.

1961–63 Presidential powers are briefly curtailed as the right wing reacts to Goulart's policies. The presidential system is reinstated after a plebiscite.

1964 Bloodless military coup under army chief General Castelo Branco, backed by the US, deposes Goulart. The 1946 liberal constitution is suspended.

1965 Branco assumes dictatorship after antimilitary parties win election in two states. He bans all existing political parties, but creates two official new ones. He is followed by a succession of military rulers. Fast-track economic development, the so-called “Brazilian Miracle,” is counterbalanced by ruthless suppression of left-wing activists.

DECISIVE MOMENT

STUDENT RIOTS, 1968

Inspired by rioters around the world, notably in France and Mexico, students took to the streets of São Paulo on September 3, 1968, to protest the military dictatorship that had seized power in 1964. Their actions provoked a brutal clampdown by the authorities. In the following years, hundreds died in left- and right-wing guerrilla warfare. State censorship of the media was tightened and many of Brazil's intellectuals were forced into exile. Emergency measures were kept in place until 1978, and the military remained in power until 1985.

Students on the rampage

A police van is enthusiastically trashed before it is torched by a protester during riots in São Paulo. Brazil's military dictators suppressed the protests with extreme brutality.

